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Have the youth chosen to compromise with the system they inherited?



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Young people constitute a large segment of our total population. The greater the proportion of young people, the greater the likelihood of cultural and social change. The nature of this change can be productive or destructive depending on how youth energies are channelised and the quality of opportunities provided. The UNDP report of 2007 states that two major factors required for effective citizenship are youth capabilities and their freedom to exercise choice. Youth participation can be gauged at several levels. Government schemes such as the National Service Scheme (2.6 million volunteers across 200 universities), the Nehru Yuva Kendra Sangathan (80 lakh non-student rural youth) and Scouts and Guides are expected to engage the youth in constructive activities. However, youth engagement is still a matter of tokenism as the impact of these networks is invisible except for a cursory mention in government reports.

Unfortunately, politics is equated with unfair power games, and hence, a significant number of the youth shun it. In the broadest sense of the term, political action is the process of change being guided by a political understanding of social realities. These processes are negligible in most student bodies which are wings of political parties. In spite of all the criticism about people's voices, the biggest event in which youth participation gets displayed is during general elections. Studies have shown that the majority of the youth strongly believe in democracy and their right to vote.

Movements such as the Narmada Bachao Andolan and Chipko largely comprised young people who questioned the nature of development and sought structural changes in governance, political and economic systems. Recently, we have seen the 'pink chaddi' campaign, which protested against the curbing of women's rights by the moral brigade. On the other hand, we had equally strong divisive campaigns against migrants from Maharashtra and Assam.

The environment in India is ready for a

social transformation. Young people would be the best agents to steer this transformation. However, the youth, by and large, have opted to compromise, rather than fight injustice. Inequality of opportunities in various sectors has left many of them frustrated and helpless. Their energies are mainly spent in the 'self-survival' process rather than in building the nation. There is no credible youth movement, no authentic leadership and lack of a common vision for the country.

Unfortunately, youth are still viewed as a group which needs supervision and intervention. We need to remember that they are the citizens of today and not of tomorrow. The hope lies in youth initiatives which show that they can be the innovators of change. If they prove limited in their vision, the fault is ours, as their doings reflect our myopic perspectives on change.

INDIA'S YOUNG DESPAIR OF ITS POLITICS AND
NEED MOTIVATION TO OVERHAUL THE SYSTEM

